

Russ Weakley

Accessibility Specialist, trainer and Design System Manager

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About me

I'm an Accessibility Specialist and Design System Manager with over 30 years of experience across design, front-end development, accessibility, and training

I've worked with major organisations in the banking and insurance sectors, helping to build, test, and scale accessible design systems and digital experiences that meet WCAG and usability standards. My expertise spans accessibility strategy and governance, inclusive design research, and organisational accessibility maturity.

I have extensive experience working with people with disabilities through focus groups, interviews, and user testing, ensuring that accessibility is grounded in lived experience rather than checklists.

At a strategic level, I help organisations embed accessibility at scale, develop sustainable design system frameworks, and create learning programs that build capability across roles and teams.

Core focus areas:

- 1. Accessibility leadership and strategy:**

Accessibility strategy, governance, compliance, testing, and organisational maturity.

- 2. Accessibility education and capability development**

Planning and leading organisation-wide learning strategies, including course design, scripting, production, and evaluation.

- 3. Design system development**

Strategy, architecture, accessibility integration, and front-end implementation.

- 4. Design research and user testing**

Inclusive research, usability testing, and evaluation of digital experiences, including direct collaboration with people with disabilities.

- 5. Technical accessibility and component architecture**

Deep understanding of HTML semantics, component behaviour, assistive technologies, browser and platform accessibility APIs, and how design system decisions propagate into real user outcomes.

Professional Experience

Head of Inclusive Training - Intopia

Nov 2021 – Present | 4 years

As Head of Inclusive Training, I lead the strategy, planning, and delivery of Intopia's accessibility education ecosystem. My role spans strategic planning, content creation, and cross-format delivery, ensuring our courses meet the evolving needs of teams building inclusive digital products.

Key responsibilities:

- Oversee the full training lifecycle – from concept and curriculum design to scripting, recording, and production.
- Collaborate with instructional, design, and technical teams to create engaging, high-impact learning experiences.
- Lead development across different delivery formats including instructor-led and eLearning.
- Partner with organisations to define and implement accessibility training strategies, embedding knowledge and capability across roles and teams.

Accessibility Principal - IAG (Insurance Australia Group)

Feb 2021 – Nov 2021 | 10 months

Led accessibility strategy, awareness, compliance, and training programs to help IAG teams deliver accessible digital products and customer experiences.

Design System Principal - IAG (Insurance Australia Group)

Mar 2018 – Jan 2021 | 2 years 11 months

Defined the vision and direction for IAG's design system (Chroma), ensuring accessibility, consistency, and scalability across digital products.

UX Designer / UI Developer - Ambiat

Dec 2015 – Mar 2018 | 2 years 4 months

Developed a design system and component library for new web applications. Responsibilities included HTML/SCSS pattern library development, UI and UX design, and accessibility integration throughout the design and build process.

UX Designer / UI Developer - WhistleOut

Feb 2015 – Dec 2015 | 11 months

Built a responsive component and layout pattern library using OOCSS, Atomic CSS, BEM, and LESS. Responsible for design systemisation, HTML/CSS/LESS framework development, and improving design consistency across sites.

UI Developer and Accessibility Specialist - Fiserv

2013 – 2014 | 1 year

Provided accessibility advice and support for UI component implementation across a large banking application. Developed HTML/CSS pattern libraries aligned with WCAG standards.

UX/UI Designer and Accessibility Specialist - Australian Museum

Jan 1998 – Dec 2013 | 17 years

Led design and development of all museum websites and web applications, focusing on accessibility, UX, and front-end pattern library development.

Web Manager - Australian Museum

Mar 2005 – Jan 2006 | 11 months

Managed all museum web projects, supervising a team of 3 full-time staff and several contractors.

UX/UI Designer and Accessibility Specialist - Max Design

Jan 1990 – Feb 2014 | 25 years

Founded and managed Max Design, a Sydney-based web development business specialising in accessibility, UX, and UI design. Clients included Sensis, Microsoft Australia, Sydney Morning Herald, Amnesty International Australia, and Reed Publishing. Delivered accessible, standards-compliant websites and led training on web standards and accessibility best practices.

Skills

Accessibility strategy and leadership

- Accessibility strategy, governance, and policy development
- WCAG interpretation, compliance planning, and risk management
- Accessibility testing and remediation (manual and automated)
- Accessibility acceptance criteria and QA integration
- Organisational accessibility maturity assessment and improvement
- Embedding accessibility into workflows, systems, and teams

Training and capability development

- Accessibility course design, scripting, and production
- Learning strategy and curriculum planning for organisations
- Training facilitation across online, self-paced, and instructor-led formats
- Building long-term organisational accessibility capability through education

Inclusive research with people with disabilities

- Extensive experience collaborating directly with people with disabilities in research, testing, and co-design
- Conducting focus groups, interviews, moderated testing, and contextual inquiry
- Adapting research and testing methods for different access needs and assistive technologies
- Strong focus on ethical, respectful, and non-tokenistic engagement

Design research and UX practice

- Inclusive research and usability testing with diverse participants
- UX and UI design for accessible digital products
- Pattern evaluation, interaction design, and usability analysis
- Information architecture and experience design grounded in real user behaviour

Design systems

- Design system strategy, architecture, and governance
- Component standards, documentation, and contribution models

- Accessibility integration and testing within design systems
- Scalable, multi-brand design system approaches
- Translating accessibility requirements into reusable components

Technical accessibility and front-end development

- Front-end development using HTML, CSS, and SCSS
- Deep understanding of semantic HTML and native browser behaviour
- Component behaviour analysis and design-to-code workflows
- Diagnosing accessibility issues across component, page, and system levels

Assistive technologies and platforms

- Practical experience testing with screen readers, keyboard navigation, and alternative input methods
- Understanding of browser accessibility trees and OS accessibility APIs
- Ability to analyse how browser, platform, and assistive technology layers interact
- Identifying root causes of accessibility issues beyond surface-level failures